

Welcome Home

Everything in this guide is somewhere we actually go. Where a place is a short walk, we say how many minutes. Where it isn't, we say that too — and tell you what the taxi costs.

IN THIS GUIDE

The first five minutes	Wi-Fi, walking times, what nobody tells you
House rules	Short, and all of them earned
Pharmacies & hospitals	Emergency numbers, and the hospital round the corner
Money & getting around	Exchange offices, ATMs, taxis, the airport
Coffee & brunch	The close ones, not the famous ones
Where we actually eat	Five minutes away, and worth the walk
Bars, clubs & the night	The stadium, Blloku, Rruga e Sales
Shops & sights	Markets, museums, the Pyramid
A spare day	Krujë, Berat, Durrës — and some Albanian

START HERE

The first five minutes

WI-FI NETWORK

[network name]

WI-FI PASSWORD

[password]

CHECK-OUT

11:00 — leave the keys on the kitchen counter

YOUR HOSTS

[your name] · [+355 ____]

WhatsApp is fastest. We're nearby — if something's broken, tell us the same day and we'll fix it.

WHERE YOU ACTUALLY ARE

You're just east of the centre, between **Rruga e Elbasanit** and the **Air Albania Stadium** — a residential, lived-in part of Tirana rather than a tourist strip. That's the good news: the tourist strip is eleven minutes away on foot, and you get to sleep.

If a taxi driver looks blank at the street name, say “*te Stadiumi Air Albania*”. Everyone knows it.

HOW LONG THINGS REALLY TAKE ON FOOT

Air Albania Stadium & its café strip	7 min
Sheshi Nënë Tereza & the Archaeological Museum	7 min
The Pyramid of Tirana	10 min
Pazari i Ri — the New Bazaar	11 min
Blloku — bars, restaurants, nightlife	11 min
House of Leaves museum	12 min
Grand Park & the Artificial Lake	13 min
Skanderbeg Square	14 min
Rruga e Sales — bar street	15 min
Tirana Airport (TIA, Rinas)	25–35 min by car

THINGS NOBODY TELLS YOU ON DAY ONE

Coffee is not a takeaway. A macchiato costs 100–150 lekë and buys you the table for two hours. Nobody brings the bill until you ask — say “*llogarinë, ju lutem*”.

Prices in “old lek.” Older Albanians quote ten times higher out of habit — if a coffee sounds like 1,500, they mean 150.

Crossing the road is a negotiation, not a right. Use the lights and make eye contact.

Tap water is fine for teeth and cooking; almost everyone drinks bottled. A 1.5 L bottle is 60–80 lekë at any corner shop.

House rules

There are only a few, and they all exist because of something that actually happened.

- 1 **Quiet between 22:00 and 08:00.** Albanian buildings are concrete and sound travels. Our neighbours are lovely and they start work early.
- 2 **No parties, and no extra guests overnight** beyond the number on the booking. If friends are in town, meet them out — you're spoilt for choice.
- 3 **No smoking inside.** The balcony is fine; there's an ashtray. Please don't flick anything over the railing.
- 4 **Shoes off inside** if you can manage it. It's the local habit and it saves the floors.
- 5 **Rubbish goes out with you.** Bag it and drop it in the green street container on the corner. Nothing left in the flat on check-out day, please.
- 6 **Air conditioning off when you leave.** Same for the lights and the water heater. It runs hot here and the bills are real.
- 7 **Towels stay in the flat.** If you're heading to the beach, tell us and we'll lend you old ones.
- 8 **Tell us early.** A dripping tap at 9 a.m. is a five-minute fix. A dripping tap discovered in a review is not.

APPLIANCES, BRIEFLY

Air conditioning — the remote's "Cool" mode at 24 °C is the sweet spot; anything lower just costs money and gives you a sore throat. **Hot water** is on a boiler; if it runs out after long showers, give it twenty minutes. **The kitchen** is yours — use what's in the cupboards, replace what you finish if you're feeling generous.

LEAVING

Check-out is 11:00. Bag the rubbish, put the dishes in the sink or the machine, close the windows, turn off the AC, and leave the keys on the kitchen counter. That's genuinely all — don't strip beds or clean, that's our job.

If we got it right, a review means more to us than a tip. If we got something wrong, tell us before you write it and we'll make it right.

Pharmacies & hospitals

112	127	128	129
ALL EMERGENCIES	AMBULANCE	FIRE	POLICE

Operators on 112 generally speak some English. Give the landmark before the street: “*afër Stadiumit Air Albania*” — near the Air Albania stadium.

PHARMACIES — FARMACI

Look for the **green cross**. Tirana has one on almost every block and there are several within three or four minutes of the door, along Rruga e Elbasanit and Rruga Pjetër Budi. Most open around 08:00 and close between 21:00 and midnight.

Albanian pharmacists are properly trained, usually speak English or Italian, and will deal with a stomach upset, a hangover, sunburn or a chest infection over the counter. Antibiotics officially need a prescription. Bring the packet of anything you take regularly — brand names differ.

Farmaci Ditë e Natë 24 HOURS · TAXI

“Day and Night” — a genuine round-the-clock chain with branches across the city, including Rruga e Dibrës. This is the 3 a.m. answer. A taxi there and back is under 800 lekë.

Wolt & Bolt Food DELIVERY

Both deliver pharmacy items — painkillers, tests, plasters, rehydration salts — until late. Usually faster than getting dressed.

HOSPITALS & CLINICS

Spitali Amavita CLOSEST · FEW MIN WALK

Rruga Pjetër Budi, opposite the Italian Cultural Institute — effectively around the corner. Private, modern, English spoken, 24-hour emergency intake. **This is where we would go first** for anything not life-threatening: a bad cut, a fever that won't shift, a suspected sprain. You'll be seen quickly.

Spitali Amerikan — American Hospital 15 MIN TAXI

The largest private network in Albania, out on Rruga Shefqet Ndroqi. The place for anything serious, for scans, or if you want a second opinion with international-standard paperwork for your insurer.

QSUT “Nënë Tereza” — University Hospital 10 MIN TAXI

The big public hospital. Free or near-free 24-hour emergency care and capable doctors, but crowded and Albanian-first. Fine in a true emergency; not for a sore throat.

PAYING FOR IT

Private hospitals want **payment up front** — cards are fine — and will give you an itemised invoice to claim on travel insurance. Ask for it in English at the desk; they do this every day. A consultation at Amavita is in the range of 3,000–6,000 lekë, which is roughly €30–60. Photograph every receipt before you leave the building.

Money & getting around

THE LEK, BRIEFLY

The currency is the **lek** (L, or ALL) — roughly **95–100 lekë to €1**, but check before you change anything. Euros are *not* generally accepted in shops and cafés. Cards work almost everywhere central; carry cash for corner shops, taxis, the bazaar and tips.

EXCHANGE OFFICES — KËMBIM VALUTOR

Exchange offices here are legal, competitive, and give a far better rate than any bank or hotel. Rates go on a board and there's normally no commission. Compare two before you hand anything over, and count the notes at the counter — everybody does.

The counters on Rruga e Elbasanit 5–8 MIN WALK

Your nearest option: several small windows along Elbasan Street and around Sheshi Nënë Tereza. Typically Mon–Sat 08:00–19:00, shorter or shut on Sunday. Fine rates for a couple of hundred euros.

The cluster near Skanderbeg Square 15 MIN WALK

Around Rruga e Barrikadave and behind the Bank of Albania there are a dozen offices within two blocks, plus the freelance changers with satchels and calculators. Both are fine, both give the best rates in the city, and many stay open until 20:00 and on Sundays.

Tirana Airport exchange OPEN FOR EVERY FLIGHT

The closest thing to round-the-clock: early morning until the last arrivals, well past midnight. **The rate is the worst in the country** — change €20 to get into town, do the rest properly next morning.

HONEST ANSWER ON 24-HOUR MONEY

There is **no true 24-hour exchange desk** in central Tirana, whatever a listing says. After about 20:00 it's an ATM, the airport, or morning. **ATMs are everywhere and work all night**. When the machine offers to convert for you, always pick **“continue without conversion”** — accepting costs 5–10%. Bank-branded machines (BKT, Credins, Raiffeisen, Intesa) charge less than standalone Euronet boxes.

TAXIS & TRANSPORT

Bolt THE APP EVERYONE USES

Download it before you arrive. Rides inside the centre run 300–600 lekë; to the airport around 1,500–2,000. Uber does not operate in Albania.

Street taxis

Agree the fare before you get in — anything within the ring road should be 500–700 lekë. City buses are 40 lekë flat, paid in cash to the conductor.

Airport — TIA, Rinas 17 KM · 25–35 MIN

Fixed-price airport taxis are around 2,500 lekë. The **Rinas Express** bus goes roughly hourly from beside the National History Museum on Skanderbeg Square for about 400 lekë — cheap, slow, fine if you travel light.

Coffee & brunch

Albania drinks more coffee per head than almost anywhere on earth, and none of it in a paper cup. Sitting down is the point.

COFFEE WITHIN A FEW MINUTES OF THE DOOR

Mulliri i Vjetër CLOSE · EVERYDAY

“The Old Mill” — the local chain that Albanians actually use, and there's a branch minutes from you. Opens early, reliable espresso, glass counter full of byrek, croissants and cream cakes. This is your default: coffee and something warm for under 300 lekë.

Mon Cheri CLOSE · SLOW START

Also right nearby, and the nicer place to sit for an hour. Pastry-forward — proper croissants, tarts, a good cappuccino. Where to go when you want the morning to take its time rather than just caffeinating.

D'Anvers CLOSE · A TREAT

Belgian chocolate house with a café attached. Come for the hot chocolate — thick, dark, unreasonable — or a coffee with something from the pralines counter. Good for a cold afternoon or a small celebration.

THE FAMOUS ONES ARE FURTHER AWAY

Every guide to Tirana sends you to **Komiteti**, **Radio Bar** or **Nouvelle Vague**. They're all genuinely good, all in or near Blloku, and all a 10–15 minute walk from here. Go one evening — but don't walk twenty minutes for a morning coffee when there's better within four.

BRUNCH

IN'S 8 MIN WALK · THE ONE TO BOOK

On Rruga Faik Konica, by the Arena — the brunch place in this part of town and the reason a lot of people come to the neighbourhood. Big plates: eggs every way, pancakes, French toast, eggs Benedict, avocado toast, proper coffee, fresh juice. Expect 700–1,400 lekë a head.

Go before 11:00 at the weekend or plan on waiting — Saturday and Sunday it's full of Tirana twenty-somethings and their sunglasses. Weekday mornings you'll walk straight in.

Byrek, the Albanian answer 2 MIN · 50–100 LEKË

Find any window with **BYREK** written on it — there are several within two minutes. Flaky pastry with spinach, cheese or minced meat, sold by the slice, eaten standing up. Best before 10:00 while the trays are still coming out of the oven. Get the spinach one.

Where we actually eat

CLOSEST TO THE DOOR

Fishop 5 MIN · OUR DEFAULT

Fish and seafood done plainly and done well — pick what looks good, they cook it, you eat it. Counter-service energy, honest prices, nothing dressed up. This is where we go when we can't be bothered to cook, which is often. Sea bass, grilled prawns, a plate of fried small fish and a beer.

Padam 10 MIN · A NICER EVENING

A boutique hotel with a walled garden restaurant hidden behind it. Mediterranean cooking, good wine, candles, very quiet. The obvious choice for a date or the one nice dinner of the trip without crossing town. Book at the weekend.

Mullixhiu 13 MIN · BOOK AHEAD

By the gate of the Grand Park, in a converted mill. Modern Albanian cooking done seriously — old mountain recipes, house-milled flour, tasting menus, the best bread in the city. If you eat one properly Albanian meal while you're here, make it this one. Reserve a few days out.

WORTH THE WALK

Era 12 MIN

The Tirana institution. Albanian and Mediterranean, a menu as long as your arm, always busy, never bad. Grilled meats, stuffed peppers, fërgesë, tavë kosi. Where to take people who don't know what they want.

Artigiano 12 MIN

Italian, and taken seriously — real pasta, proper Neapolitan pizza, a wine list that isn't an afterthought. Albania's relationship with Italy runs deep and this is the good end of it.

Morsi 12 MIN

Small plates, cocktails, low light, young crowd. More about a good three hours than any single dish. Start the evening here.

Salt 14 MIN · RESERVE

Tirana's cool-kid restaurant and still one of the best. Inventive, seasonal, well-run. You will not get a table on a Friday by walking in — book.

ORDER THESE AT LEAST ONCE

Fërgesë — peppers, tomato and cottage cheese baked in a clay dish, eaten with bread. **Tavë kosi** — lamb baked under yoghurt and egg; the national dish. **Specia me gjizë** — stuffed peppers. **Qofte** — grilled meatballs. **Raki** — the homemade grape spirit that arrives free at the end of the meal. Say yes once.

Tippling: not obligatory and never automatic. Round up, or leave 5–10% if the service was good. **Booking:** most places take reservations by phone or Instagram DM, which is genuinely how Tirana works.

Bars, clubs & where the night goes

Tirana starts late. Dinner at nine, bars from eleven, clubs after one. Turning up at ten will feel like you've broken in.

AROUND THE AIR ALBANIA STADIUM — YOUR CLOSEST OPTION

Seven minutes from the door, and underrated. The ground floor of the stadium and the streets around it are wall-to-wall **cafés, lounge bars and shisha terraces** — big outdoor seating, open very late, a mostly local crowd, and far less tourist tax than Blloku. There's a cinema, a food court and a rooftop or two in the same complex.

This is the right call for a drink you don't have to plan, or a long summer evening outside. Check whether Albania or one of the Tirana clubs is playing while you're here — the whole quarter turns into one enormous party on match nights, and the atmosphere is worth seeing even if you don't go in.

BLLOKU

Eleven minutes on foot. Until 1991 this was the sealed compound where the Party elite lived and ordinary Albanians were not allowed to walk. It is now the densest concentration of bars in the country, which is a joke everyone here has already made.

Puls 11 MIN · LOUD, LATE

The name people give you first. Big room, commercial and house, packed from one in the morning, keeps going. Dress up a bit.

Honestly, though — don't plan Blloku. There are thirty-odd bars inside four blocks and half of them will have changed name by next season. Walk down **Rruga Pjetër Bogdani** or **Rruga Ismail Qemali** after eleven on a Friday or Saturday, listen at the doors, and go into whatever sounds right. That's what everyone who lives here does. Cocktails run 600–1,000 lekë, beer 250–400.

RRUGA E SALES

Officially Rruga Mustafa Matohiti; nobody calls it that. A narrow street that has quietly become the best strip in the city — wine bars, small restaurants, coffee in the afternoon and drinks until late, the whole thing one long terrace in summer. About 15 minutes on foot, or a 300 lekë taxi.

Patela by Naga 15 MIN · START HERE

The one to head for on that street. Good food, better crowd, the kind of place that works for dinner at nine and is still the right place at one. Then walk the rest of the street.

TWO MORE, FOR THE RECORD

Rooftops — the revolving bar at the top of Sky Tower is a tourist thing and also genuinely lovely at sunset.

Pazari i Ri — the New Bazaar quarter is full of small restaurants and bars that fill up after work; a good, calmer alternative to Blloku on a weeknight.

Getting home — Bolt runs all night and a ride back from anywhere in this list is 300–500 lekë. Please be quiet on the stairs.

Shops, and things to see

GROCERIES & DAILY BITS

The corner mini-markets 1-3 MIN

There are several within a couple of minutes and they are what you'll actually use: bread, eggs, water, beer, yoghurt, tomatoes, coffee, cleaning things. Open roughly 07:00 to 22:00, seven days. Cash is easiest.

Pazari i Ri — the New Bazaar 11 MIN · GO IN THE MORNING

The best food shopping in Tirana: fruit and vegetables that taste of something, mountain cheese, honey, olives, spices, homemade raki in reused bottles. Prices are fair, haggling isn't expected, and the surrounding streets are full of good cheap restaurants.

A full supermarket shop 10-15 MIN OR DELIVERY

The bigger chains — Spar, Conad — are a walk or a short taxi away, not around the corner. If you want a proper stock-up, honestly just order it on **Wolt** or **Bolt Food**; both deliver groceries in under an hour and it costs almost nothing.

MUSEUMS & THE OBVIOUS SIGHTS

National Archaeological Museum 7 MIN · CLOSEST

On Sheshi Nënë Tereza, and the nearest museum to your front door. Small, cheap, and a genuinely good hour — Illyrian bronze, Roman mosaics, Butrint finds. The easy option for a hot afternoon or a rainy one.

House of Leaves 12 MIN · DO THIS ONE

The former headquarters of the Sigurimi, the secret police, left much as it was found: bugging equipment, surveillance files, the machinery of watching everybody. Quiet, chilling, beautifully done. If you visit one museum in Tirana, this is it.

Bunk'Art 2 13 MIN

A nuclear bunker under the Ministry of Interior, now a museum about the police state and the people it destroyed. Heavy, excellent, about ninety minutes. (There is a second, much larger Bunk'Art out under Dajti mountain — half a day and a 20-minute taxi each way. Only worth it if this one leaves you wanting more.)

The Pyramid of Tirana 10 MIN · FREE

Built as a mausoleum for the dictator, abandoned, graffitied for thirty years, and reborn as a white concrete hill you can walk up. Climb it at sunset — free, and the best short walk in the city.

Skanderbeg Square, Et'hem Bey Mosque & the clock tower 14 MIN

The centre. Enormous, car-free, slightly surreal. The mosque's painted interior survived the ban on religion and is worth stepping into — shoes off, shoulders covered.

Grand Park & the Artificial Lake 13 MIN

The city's lungs: a running loop around the water, cafés on the bank, families everywhere on Sunday. Best early in the morning.

Dajti Ekspres cable car 20 MIN TAXI + 15 MIN RIDE

Up the mountain behind the city for the whole valley laid out beneath you. Clear days only — in haze you'll see nothing. Restaurant and walking trails at the top.

If you have a spare day

Krujë 1 HOUR

Castle on a cliff, Skanderbeg's museum, and an Ottoman bazaar street that's touristy but beautiful. The easiest half-day from Tirana.

Durrës 45 MIN

The sea, plus the largest Roman amphitheatre in the Balkans sitting incongruously in the middle of town. Good for a swim and a fish lunch.

Berat 2 HOURS

“The city of a thousand windows” — UNESCO-listed Ottoman houses stacked up a hillside, castle at the top. Worth an overnight if you can.

Shkodër & the north 2 HOURS

Gateway to the Albanian Alps, Lake Koman ferry and Theth. Not a day trip — but if you have three days spare, go.

Buses leave from the regional terminals rather than a central station; ask us and we'll point you at the right one, or a driver for the day costs €80–120 and is often the better answer for two or more people.

ENOUGH ALBANIAN TO BE LIKED

Përshëndetje per-shen-DET-yeh

Hello (formal). *Ç'kemi* — “chkemi” — is the casual one.

Faleminderit fah-leh-min-DEH-rit

Thank you. Worth learning properly; it lands every time.

Ju lutem yoo LOO-tem

Please / you're welcome.

Po / Jo poh / yoh

Yes / no.

Sa kushton? sah koosh-TON

How much is it?

Një kafe, ju lutem

One coffee, please.

Llogarinë, ju lutem

The bill, please. You will always have to ask.

Gëzuar! g'-ZOO-ar

Cheers. Said with eye contact.

Më falni

Excuse me / sorry.

Mirupafshim

Goodbye.

A small head shake can mean *yes* here, and a sharp upward nod with a tut can mean *no* — the opposite of what you expect. Watch the eyebrows.

ONE LAST THING

Tirana rewards wandering more than planning. Nothing in this guide is more than a quarter of an hour away, most of it is far closer, and the best things that will happen to you here are not in it.

Anything at all — message us. [your name] · [+355 __ __ __]